MERCY'S ANATOMY

Season 1, Episode 2

"The Second Cut"

Episode 1x02. The counterpart of *Grey's Anatomy* 1x02. Narrator: Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock

In-story dates: Thursday, July 7, 2005, 4:31 AM through Friday, July 8, 2005, 1:14 PM

Script: Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag. 43 scenes. Standard: MA-009

Depends on MA-001 through MA-011 and episode 1x01

EPISODE PDF PACKAGE (MA-009 §6): 1. Title page and cast (with ages on July 1, 2005). 2. Script. 3. Media Companion. 4. Continuity Sheet.

Cast in Order of Appearance (Ages on Thursday, July 7, 2005)

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock	Surgical Intern (narrator)	Jan 5, 1979	26
Dr. Harmony Divine	Surgical Intern	Jun 19, 1979	26
Dr. Raven Ellison	Surgical Intern	Dec 3, 1979	25
Dr. Amond Baker	Surgical Intern	Feb 10, 1979	26
Dr. Arianna Cummings	Surgical Intern	Oct 25, 1979	25
Dr. Esther Smilley	Surgical Intern	Sep 20, 1979	25
Raymond 'Big Ray' Toles	Chief of Security	Jan 1, 1960	45
Dr. Elxa Bullock	Surgical Resident	Aug 29, 1977	27
Jalen Price (new)	Patient: magnet ingestion, bowel perforation	Oct 2, 1995	9
Bernice Price (new)	Jalen's grandmother; home health aide	Dec 4, 1946	58
Nurse Gloria Pettiford	Head ER Nurse	Apr 14, 1952	53
Lowell Gaskins (new)	Patient Financial Services	Mar 27, 1961	44
Dr. Leland Graves	Chief of Neurosurgery	Apr 18, 1953	52
Earl Wynn	Patient: post-op dissection, tamponade	Nov 2, 1946	58
Darlene Wynn (new)	Earl's wife	May 19, 1950	55
Dr. Robert Bullock	Chief of Cardiothoracic Surgery	Feb 10, 1956	49
Nurse Kendra Wallace	Surgical Floor Nurse	May 30, 1980	25
Dr. Natasha Donohue	Chief of Surgery	Jun 2, 1958	47
Dr. Sylvia Rountree	President and CEO, QGH	Dec 2, 1951	53
Dr. Isaiah Crump (new)	Chief of Pediatric Surgery	Mar 11, 1944	61
Nurse Yvette Banks	Lead Scrub Nurse	Dec 1, 1963	41
Augustus Freeland (new)	Patient: essential tremor (DBS)	Feb 22, 1931	74
Celia Montague, LCSW	Social Worker	May 6, 1966	39
Hattie 'Miss Hattie' Lomax	Head Cook	Mar 3, 1945	60
Lillian Divine	Harmony's mother	Feb 14, 1952	53
Oliver 'Ollie' Freeman	Night Custodian	Nov 8, 1948	56

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Bernadette 'Bernie' Watkins	Executive Assistant to the Chief	Jun 6, 1950	55
Lamar Pittman	Patient: discharge	Jan 14, 1971	34
Russell Jeffries	Elxa's husband	Apr 3, 1975	30

Also appearing: a CNN anchor (on TV), two NYPD officers, night nurses, a neurophysiologist, and a 22-year-old appendectomy patient. Mentioned: Keisha (Mr. Freeland’s granddaughter) and Mrs. Tolliver (a Ravenswood neighbor).

Black don't crack (C-018): every regular reads several years younger than their age on screen. The ages above are exact and binding.

COLD OPEN

1 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - NIGHT
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 4:31 AM

The chef's kitchen is no longer empty. Every burner is going. HARMONY (26), in scrubs and a headscarf, is frying turkey sausage, scrambling eggs and stirring grits like she's feeding a church. RAVEN (25) stands at the counter assembling one grilled cheese with surgical precision.

MARC (26) shuffles in, half asleep, in a Howard T-shirt, and stops dead at the sight of the stove.

MARC (V.O.)
A week. That's how long it takes the human body to adapt to almost anything. Altitude. Grief. Thirty-hour shifts.

MARC (V.O.)
Roommates take longer.

MARC
It's four-thirty in the morning.

HARMONY
Breakfast is the most important meal of the day.

MARC
It's not day. It's night with ambition.

RAVEN
(holding up her sandwich)
Perfect grilled cheese. Golden on both sides. Cheese reaches the edges but doesn't escape. Watch.

She cuts it in half. A clean, molten line. She holds it up to the light like a diamond.

MARC
That is a perfect grilled cheese.

RAVEN
It's the only thing I can cook. I made it perfect so nobody would notice.

Harmony's PAGER buzzes on the counter. She checks it and closes her eyes.

ON THE PAGER SCREEN: "DID U EAT. -- MOMMY"

HARMONY
She found out I moved. She's been paging every two hours. One just said "THE HOUSE IS QUIET."

MARC
Page her back.

HARMONY
And say what?

MARC
"Ate grits. The house is loud." (beat) Give me some of those grits.

2 INT. OLD MAIN - RESIDENTS' LOUNGE - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 5:38 AM

The interns are crowded in front of the wall TV. Nobody speaks. AMOND (26), ARIANNA (25) and ESTHER (25) are already there in scrubs. Marc, Harmony and Raven come in, laughing, and stop.

ON THE TV: CNN, LIVE. "EXPLOSIONS ROCK LONDON TRANSPORT SYSTEM." Footage of a red double-decker bus with its roof torn away in Tavistock Square. The crawl: "...multiple blasts on the Underground during morning rush hour ... dozens feared dead ... New York raises transit alert level..."

RAVEN
(quiet)
Oh, God.

CNN ANCHOR (ON TV)
...three explosions on the Underground within fifty seconds of each other, just before nine a.m. London time, and a fourth on a bus less than an hour later. British officials are calling it a coordinated attack on the public transit system...

Harmony takes out her RAZR and dials. She waits. Her hand is shaking.

HARMONY
(into the phone)
Daddy? It's me. Where are you? (beat) Okay. Okay. I know you're fine, I just... are there police on the... okay. Okay. I love you too. Drive safe. Drive SAFE.

She hangs up. Everyone's looking at her.

HARMONY
He drives the Q4. He's on the road right now.

AMOND
It's a bus in Queens.

HARMONY
It was a bus in London.

Nobody has an answer for that. Esther puts a hand on Harmony's shoulder. Arianna turns away from the screen, jaw tight.

MARC (V.O.)
Four years ago, this city learned that the worst day can start on a perfectly normal morning.

MARC (V.O.)
So every normal morning since, we've held our breath a little.

3 INT. OLD MAIN - LOBBY - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 5:52 AM

Two NYPD OFFICERS stand by the entrance in tactical vests. BIG RAY TOLES (45), Chief of Security, six-foot-seven, briefs a pair of his own guards. Lockwood's Lamp burns steadily in its glass case.

BIG RAY
City's on alert. The NYPD's put cops on every subway platform and the bridges. If we get a mass casualty call, we lock the ambulance bay to EMS only. Nobody walks in off Jackson Avenue without being seen.

Marc passes with coffee. Big Ray nods at him.

BIG RAY
Doc. You take the 7 in?

MARC
I walk. Ten minutes.

BIG RAY
Good. Keep walking.

Marc glances at the lamp. It burns perfectly still.

MARC
It's not flickering.

BIG RAY
(not smiling)
Then let's keep it that way.

4 INT. OLD MAIN - RESIDENTS' LOUNGE - THE BOARD - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 6:05 AM

ELXA BULLOCK (27) stands at the Board, marker in hand. Her five interns, plus Arianna (on loan from Dr. Boykin's team), crowd around.

ELXA
London is not our problem until it is. If this city gets hit, every one of you will be in the Pit within ten minutes, and you will be useful. Until then, there's work.

She uncaps the marker. At the top of the Board, in big red letters, she writes: "THE CUT."

ELXA
Here's your incentive program, since I'm told your generation needs one. The best intern on my service this week, the one who does the most for their patients with the fewest mistakes, gets an appendectomy tomorrow morning. Skin to skin. Start to finish. Your name in the op note as the surgeon.

Amond's eyes light up like he just saw the face of God. Arianna steps closer.

ARIANNA
Can Boykin's interns compete?

ELXA
You're on my service today. So yes. God help us all.

ARIANNA
(to Harmony, sweetly)
You already had your cut, right, Double-O?

Harmony looks at the floor.

ELXA
(sharp)
Cummings. Rule four. Egos never. (to all of them) Bullock: Pit, peds consults. Smilley: you're on Dr. Graves's service today, he asked for you by description. "The one who watched the eyes."

Esther's face does something it hasn't done all week. It lights up.

ELXA
Baker: CT step-down, Dr. Robert Bullock's post-ops. Ellison: floors, discharges, and Mrs. Pope's follow-up. Divine: you have Mr. Pittman's discharge.

HARMONY
(small)
Okay.

ELXA
Cummings, you're with me. Go.

They scatter. Marc lingers. Elxa turns away to the counter... and suddenly grips the edge of it. Her face goes gray.

5 INT. OLD MAIN - RESIDENTS' LOUNGE - CONTINUOUS
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 6:12 AM

Elxa grabs the trash can by the microwave and throws up into it, quick and violent. Marc, halfway out the door, spins back.

MARC
Elxa...

ELXA
(wiping her mouth, ferocious)
Dr. Bullock.

MARC
(lowering his voice)
Dr. Bullock. You okay?

ELXA
Somebody microwaved fish. In my lounge. At six in the morning. When I find out who it was, there will be a homicide, and I'll do my own autopsy.

Marc looks at the microwave. It's empty and clean.

MARC
Nobody microwaved anything.

ELXA
GO.

He goes. Elxa stares at the trash can, breathing hard. Then she straightens her coat and walks out like nothing happened.

SMASH TO:

MAIN TITLE: MERCY'S ANATOMY

ACT ONE

6 INT. PELL PAVILION - THE PIT - PEDS BAY - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 6:41 AM

JALEN PRICE (9), small for his age, curled on a gurney in a Yankees jersey, clutching his belly. A plastic basin is beside him. His grandmother, BERNICE PRICE (58), still in her home-health-aide uniform, holds his hand. NURSE GLORIA PETTIFORD (53) hangs a bag of fluids.

Marc pulls the curtain back.

MARC
Hey, man. I'm Dr. Bullock. I heard your stomach's having a bad day.

JALEN
(miserable)
It's having a bad week.

BERNICE
Three days of throwing up. I thought it was a virus. Then this morning he couldn't stand up straight.

Marc gently palpates Jalen's belly. Jalen winces all over.

MARC
Jalen, I'm going to ask you a weird question, and you won't be in trouble no matter what the answer is. Did you swallow anything? Anything at all?

Jalen looks at his grandmother. Looks at the ceiling.

JALEN
...Define "swallow."

GLORIA
(handing Marc a film)
X-ray's back, Doc.

Marc holds the abdominal film up to the light. In Jalen's belly, two small, bright white, round objects sit in different loops of bowel, pressed against each other through the bowel walls.

MARC
Those are magnets.

JALEN
(quiet)
For my science fair. The magnet race car. I was holding them in my mouth while I built it, and then I sneezed.

BERNICE
You swallowed MAGNETS?

JALEN
Just two. One on Sunday, one on Monday. I didn't want to waste the first one.

MARC
(gently, to Bernice)
One magnet usually passes. Two is a problem. They find each other through the bowel walls and they squeeze, like a clamp. The tissue in between dies. They can punch holes right through his intestine.

BERNICE
(going pale)
Holes.

MARC
I'm calling Dr. Crump, the Chief of Pediatric Surgery. Right now.

7 INT. PELL PAVILION - PIT CORRIDOR - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 6:59 AM

Marc hangs up the wall phone. A man in a cheap gray suit with a clipboard is already waiting: LOWELL GASKINS (44), Patient Financial Services. Pleasant. Relentless.

GASKINS
Dr. Bullock? Lowell Gaskins, Financial Services. Peds Bay 2, Jalen Price. He's self-pay. No insurance on file.

MARC
He's nine. He swallowed magnets. He's going to surgery.

GASKINS
And he'll get it, if he needs it emergently. That's federal law, EMTALA. But once he's stabilized, if there's no coverage, our policy is to arrange a transfer to Elmhurst. They're the public hospital. They have a whole system for this.

MARC
You want to transfer a nine-year-old after bowel surgery to save money?

GASKINS
I want this hospital to stay open, Doctor. We lost thirty-eight million dollars last year. Every uninsured surgical stay at QGH costs us about forty thousand. Elmhurst is an excellent hospital, and it gets city money to do exactly this.

MARC
(tight)
That's not a reason. That's a spreadsheet.

GASKINS
(kindly, like he's had this conversation a thousand times)
It's both, Doctor. That's the job. I'll have the paperwork ready for once he's stable.

He walks off. Marc stares after him.

8 INT. PELL PAVILION - NEUROSURGERY - DR. GRAVES'S OFFICE - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 7:10 AM

DR. LELAND GRAVES (52) reads a chart without looking up. Esther stands in the doorway, crisp, eager and trying not to look eager.

GRAVES
You're the one who watched the eyes.

ESTHER
Yes, sir. Esther Smilley.

GRAVES
Bullock got the credit. You noticed the focal onset. I asked who noticed. A nurse told me. (beat) Don't let other people take your observations, Smilley. Write them in the chart.

ESTHER
He didn't take it. I gave it to him.

GRAVES
Then don't do that either.

He hands her a chart.

GRAVES
Augustus Freeland. Seventy-four. Essential tremor, thirty years, getting worse. Retired jazz pianist. He played at the Blue Note for twenty years. Now he can't hold a coffee cup. I'm putting a deep brain stimulator in his thalamus this afternoon, and he'll be awake for it.

ESTHER
Awake.

GRAVES
We have to test him while we place the electrode. He'll do tasks, and we'll watch the tremor stop. Or we won't. (beat) You'll be at his head, talking to him for three hours, keeping him calm, keeping him still. Can you talk for three hours?

ESTHER
(beat)
My mother says I could talk the paint off a wall.

GRAVES
Then go meet him before he talks you out of it.

9 INT. PELL PAVILION - CT STEP-DOWN UNIT - ROOM 3 - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 7:24 AM

EARL WYNN (58), six days after his aortic dissection repair, sits up in bed with a sternal pillow hugged to his chest. His wife, DARLENE WYNN (55), sits next to him doing a word search. DR. ROBERT BULLOCK (49) reads the chart. Amond stands at attention.

EARL
There he is! The kid who checked my other arm!

AMOND
How are you feeling, Mr. Wynn?

EARL
Like a man who got sawed in half and put back together by a guy who listens to saxophone.

ROBERT
(dry)
It's Coltrane. Be grateful.

DARLENE
He's been telling the nurses he's the bionic man.

ROBERT
(to Amond)
Day six. New atrial fibrillation last night, rate-controlled. Chest tube output was low, so we pulled it yesterday. Baker, you're on him tonight. Watch him.

AMOND
For what, specifically?

ROBERT
For anything you'd hate to have missed. (beat) After cardiac surgery, Dr. Baker, the heart sometimes bleeds slowly into the sac around it. Quietly. Then all at once.

AMOND
Tamponade.

ROBERT
If it happens, you'll have about ten minutes. Know what you'll do before you need to.

He leaves. Earl looks at Amond.

EARL
Is he always like that?

AMOND
(with deep admiration)
I hope so.

10 INT. PELL PAVILION - 4TH FLOOR SUPPLY ROOM - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 7:41 AM

Shelves of gauze and IV tubing. Arianna grabs a box of gloves. NURSE KENDRA WALLACE (25), sharp, pretty, done with interns, reaches past her for saline flushes. They're closer than they need to be.

KENDRA
You're the one who named that girl Double-O.

ARIANNA
It caught on. I'm a visionary.

KENDRA
You're mean.

ARIANNA
I'm accurate.

KENDRA
(looking at her)
Mm. You're something.

A beat too long. Arianna's composure slips. Just a hair.

ARIANNA
(recovering, grabbing the gloves)
I have patients.

KENDRA
(smiling, as Arianna leaves)
Sure you do.

11 INT. OLD MAIN - 3RD FLOOR WOMEN'S RESTROOM - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 7:55 AM

An old tiled bathroom. Harmony stands in front of the last stall. On the inside of the door, in black Sharpie: "DOUBLE-O DIVINE: LICENSED TO KILL." Below it, in a different hand: "007!!" with a little drawing of a gun.

Raven comes in, sees Harmony's face and sees the door.

RAVEN
Oh, honey. I'll get bleach. There's some under the...

HARMONY
Leave it.

RAVEN
Harmony.

HARMONY
Leave it. I froze. It's true. If I scrub it off, it's still true. I'll just have to look at it until it isn't.

Raven looks at her. Then at the door.

RAVEN
That's the most Christian thing I've ever heard in a bathroom.

Harmony laughs, wet and miserable.

12 INT. OLD MAIN - CHIEF OF SURGERY'S OFFICE - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 8:02 AM

Natasha sits behind her desk. Across from her, in a navy suit and pearls, sits DR. SYLVIA ROUNTREE (53), President and CEO of Queens Grace, a binder of budget reports open on her lap.

SYLVIA
Thirty-eight million last year. We're on pace for forty-four this year. The bond rating agencies are calling me twice a week, Natasha.

NATASHA
Then don't answer.

SYLVIA
I'm serious. If we don't change the payer mix, we have two years. Maybe three. After that it's a merger, a sale or a closure.

NATASHA
We are not closing a hospital that's been open since 1889 because Medicaid pays us sixty cents on the dollar.

SYLVIA
(leaning forward)
Then let me say the thing that nobody in this building says out loud. Your father could fix this with one phone call. One. The Donohue Foundation spent eighteen billion dollars last year. We need forty million.

Natasha's face goes still.

NATASHA
My father doesn't run this hospital.

SYLVIA
He doesn't have to run it. He has to fund it.

NATASHA
The minute Queens Grace takes Donohue money, it stops being Queens Grace and becomes the Donohues' charity project in Queens. Every decision I make gets second-guessed. Every surgeon I hire gets called a favor. Every patient becomes a press release. (beat) No.

SYLVIA
(closing the binder)
Then find me forty million dollars by the fall, Chief. Because I can't.

13 INT. PELL PAVILION - PRE-OP HOLDING - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 8:17 AM

DR. ISAIAH CRUMP (61), Chief of Pediatric Surgery, white-haired, bow tie, three years from retirement and gentle with children in a way that's almost spiritual, examines Jalen. Marc stands with Bernice.

CRUMP
(to Jalen)
You built a magnet race car, son?

JALEN
It was going to be really fast.

CRUMP
I believe it. (standing, to Bernice) Mrs. Price, the magnets have been stuck for three days. There's almost certainly damage to his bowel. We need to go in, take out the magnets and repair whatever they've done.

BERNICE
(to Marc, low)
How much is that going to cost?

MARC
Don't worry about that right now.

BERNICE
Baby, I'm a home health aide. I have worried about "how much" every day of my life. I'm raising him by myself since his mama passed. I don't have insurance for me, let alone him.

Marc kneels so he's at her eye level.

MARC
Mrs. Price. Right now, the only thing that matters is what's in his belly. Let me worry about the rest. I'm very good at worrying. I'm a professional.

She studies him. Nods. She doesn't believe him, but she wants to.

CRUMP
(looking at the monitor, frowning)
Dr. Bullock. His pressure.

Marc turns. The monitor reads 78/40. Jalen's heart rate is climbing: 140... 148...

JALEN
(weak)
Grandma, my stomach is really hot now...

CRUMP
(calm, fast)
He's perforated. He's going septic. We're going now. Somebody call OR 6!

Bernice grabs Jalen's hand as the nurses swarm and the gurney starts rolling. Marc runs with it.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

14 INT. PELL PAVILION - OR 6 - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 8:51 AM

A pediatric OR with cartoon animals on the walls, now ignored. Jalen is open on the table. Crump operates, with Elxa first-assisting and Marc on retraction. Yvette Banks passes instruments.

CRUMP
Running the bowel. Gently. There.

He lifts a loop of small intestine. Two magnets, fused together through two separate loops of bowel, have created a dark, ugly patch of dead tissue. There's a small hole in it, leaking.

ELXA
Two perforations. And there's a fistula between the loops.

CRUMP
Four holes, if we count honestly. These little things don't care. (beat) Dr. Bullock, what do we do?

MARC
Take out the magnets. Resect the damaged segment. Anastomosis. Wash out the belly.

CRUMP
How much bowel?

MARC
As little as possible. He's nine. He'll need every inch.

CRUMP
(pleased)
Pediatric surgery in one sentence. Clamps.

Crump works. Elxa watches Marc sideways as he retracts: steady, focused, completely silent.

CRUMP
You want peds, Dr. Bullock?

MARC
Since I was eleven.

CRUMP
Why eleven?

MARC
My uncle took me to a children's hospital in Atlanta. He's a pediatric oncologist. There was a girl my age with no hair who beat me at chess four times. I lost so bad. I thought, I want to work wherever she is.

Elxa glances up at him over her mask. She knows that uncle. She doesn't say a word.

CRUMP
(smiling under his mask)
Good reason. The best reason.

15 INT. PELL PAVILION - OR 6 GALLERY - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 9:20 AM

Amond and Arianna sit in the gallery, watching. Amond eats almonds from a bag. Arianna takes notes she doesn't need.

ARIANNA
He's retracting. Big deal. A coat rack could retract.

AMOND
A coat rack doesn't answer the "how much bowel" question correctly.

ARIANNA
You're defending him?

AMOND
I'm stating facts. I'm going to beat him for the Cut. Fairly. With facts.

ARIANNA
(eyes narrowing)
You think you've got it.

AMOND
I held an aorta on day one. I'm managing a post-op dissection patient tonight. You've done rectal exams and attitude.

ARIANNA
(beat)
I'm very good at attitude.

AMOND
That's not a procedure.

16 INT. PELL PAVILION - ROOM 618 - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 10:04 AM

A private room. AUGUSTUS FREELAND (74), elegant, with a white goatee and a cashmere cardigan even in July, sits in bed. His hands rest on the blanket, and they're shaking: a constant, rhythmic tremor. A framed photo on the tray table: a young Augustus at a piano in a smoky club, 1961.

Esther sits beside him with the consent form. He's trying to sign it. The pen skitters across the page.

FREELAND
Thirty years ago I could play Art Tatum's runs with my eyes closed. Now look. I write my name like a seismograph.

ESTHER
It's legible. Mostly. The "F" is very confident.

FREELAND
(laughing)
You're kind. Kind people make the worst liars.

ESTHER
Why now, Mr. Freeland? You've had the tremor thirty years. Why do the surgery now?

He looks at the photo.

FREELAND
My granddaughter Keisha gets married on Saturday, July sixteenth. At Abyssinian. She asked me to play her down the aisle, the way I played for her mother. (beat) I said yes before I remembered I can't.

Esther is very still.

ESTHER
My father had beautiful hands. He owned a hardware store in Roxbury. He could fix anything with them. A clock, a radio, a broken bike. I used to sit on the counter and watch him.

FREELAND
What happened to him?

ESTHER
(beat)
Somebody took him. In the store. I was seven.

Freeland reaches over with his trembling hand and puts it on hers. It shakes. She holds it anyway.

FREELAND
Then you know about hands.

ESTHER
I know about hands. (beat) This afternoon, you're going to be awake, and I'm going to be right at your head. When they turn it on, I want you to play something for me. On your blanket, on the drapes, anything.

FREELAND
What do you want to hear?

ESTHER
Surprise me.

17 INT. OLD MAIN - RESIDENTS' LOUNGE - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 11:02 AM

Raven bursts in waving a newspaper. Harmony, at the table finishing discharge paperwork, looks up.

INSERT: QUEENS CHRONICLE, THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005. Headline: "QUEENS GRACE WELCOMES 18 NEW SURGEONS-IN-TRAINING." Subhead: "Interns take 'Dawn Oath' on hospital roof; Chief warns of 'the hardest year of their lives.'" A grainy photo of the interns on the roof, their backs to the camera, facing Manhattan.

RAVEN
We're in the paper! Look! That's the back of my head!

HARMONY
(taking it, reading)
"Some of you will not finish." (beat) She really said that to the newspaper.

RAVEN
And look, the next page. "New York Loses 2012 Olympics to London." That was yesterday. And then today...

She trails off. Today, London is burning. They both look at the silent TV, still on CNN.

HARMONY
My daddy drove the Q4 past the whole city today, and he called me at ten to say there are cops on every corner of Jamaica Avenue and he's never felt so safe and so scared at the same time.

RAVEN
(sitting down next to her)
That's what everybody feels like today.

Arianna walks in, grabs a coffee and reads the headline over Raven's shoulder.

ARIANNA
Eighteen of us. "Some of you will not finish." (looking at Harmony) Odds are on you, Double-O.

Raven stands up.

RAVEN
Hey. Gary, Indiana.

ARIANNA
(turning)
What?

RAVEN
My grandma raised me in Yamacraw Village. You know what that is? It's projects in Savannah. And she told me there's two kinds of people who make fun of other people's fear. The ones who've never been scared, and the ones who are scared all the time. (beat) Which one are you?

Arianna stares at her. For once she has nothing. She takes her coffee and leaves.

HARMONY
(stunned)
Raven.

RAVEN
(sitting back down, shaking slightly)
I've never done that in my life. Was it okay?

HARMONY
It was beautiful.

18 INT. OLD MAIN - PATIENT FINANCIAL SERVICES - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 12:21 PM

A windowless office with beige cubicles. Gaskins sits behind a desk with a framed photo of his own kids. Marc stands in front of him, still in his OR cap.

GASKINS
He's stable. Post-op. Good news. Transport to Elmhurst is booked for six p.m. Their pediatric surgery team has accepted him.

MARC
He had four holes in his intestine six hours ago. He's on antibiotics, an NG tube, a fresh anastomosis. You want to put him in an ambulance on the BQE at rush hour?

GASKINS
The transfer is clinically appropriate. Dr. Crump signed off that he's stable for transfer.

MARC
Dr. Crump signed because you told him the bed's needed.

GASKINS
(patient)
Dr. Bullock. I have three kids. I don't like this. I don't write the rules. But Queens Grace is drowning, and if this hospital closes, nobody in western Queens has a hospital. Not Jalen. Not anybody.

MARC
So we save the hospital by throwing out the patients it exists for.

GASKINS
(beat)
Transport's at six. I'm sorry.

19 INT. OLD MAIN - SOCIAL WORK OFFICE - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 12:46 PM

A cramped office overflowing with binders, forms and plants that should be dead but aren't. CELIA MONTAGUE (39), LCSW, reading glasses on top of her head, listens to Marc pace.

MARC
He's nine. His grandmother's a home health aide with no insurance. He has a fresh bowel resection. They want to ship him to Elmhurst at six, and Elmhurst is a great hospital, but he's not a package.

CELIA
Is the grandmother working?

MARC
Full time. Fifty hours a week.

CELIA
Income?

MARC
I don't know. Not a lot.

CELIA
(pulling a binder down without looking)
Then he's probably eligible for Child Health Plus. New York State insurance for kids. It's been around since 1991, and half the families who qualify have never heard of it.

MARC
(stopping)
Can you enroll him today?

CELIA
Not "enroll." But a hospital can grant presumptive eligibility to a child who's likely eligible. Temporary coverage, effective immediately, while the full application processes. If he has coverage, he's not self-pay.

MARC
If he's not self-pay...

CELIA
Then Financial Services has no reason to transfer him. (beat) I need proof of income, proof of address and his birth certificate or some other proof of age. Today. And that's a lot of paper for a woman who's been sitting by an OR since six.

MARC
Where does she live?

CELIA
The address on the chart says the Ravenswood Houses. Twenty minutes' walk. (looking at him over her glasses) And Dr. Bullock? If the transfer paperwork were to take a little longer to reach the Pit than usual...

MARC
I didn't hear the second part.

CELIA
(going back to her binder)
I didn't say the second part.

20 INT. OLD MAIN - CAFETERIA - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 1:14 PM

Lunch rush. The sign today: "THURSDAY: OXTAILS. ASK NICELY." MISS HATTIE LOMAX (60) runs the line. Harmony, Raven and Esther are at the table.

Through the cafeteria doors comes LILLIAN DIVINE (53), in her Sunday church hat on a Thursday, carrying four foil trays stacked to her chin.

HARMONY
(sinking in her chair)
No. No, no, no.

LILLIAN
(spotting her, booming)
THERE'S my baby!

Every head in the cafeteria turns. Lillian sets down the trays: baked macaroni and cheese, fried chicken, collard greens and a pound cake.

LILLIAN
You don't answer your pager, you move out without telling your mother, so your mother comes to you. (to Esther and Raven) Hello, I'm Harmony's mother. Eat. You girls are too thin.

RAVEN
(already reaching)
Yes, ma'am.

Miss Hattie comes around the counter, ladle in hand, eyeing the trays like an invading army.

MISS HATTIE
Ma'am. This is my cafeteria.

LILLIAN
And this is my daughter's lunch.

A standoff. Two Black women of a certain age, staring each other down over macaroni and cheese. The whole cafeteria holds its breath.

MISS HATTIE
(leaning in, studying the mac and cheese)
Sharp cheddar?

LILLIAN
Sharp, and a little smoked gouda.

MISS HATTIE
(beat)
Evaporated milk?

LILLIAN
I'm not an animal.

Miss Hattie nods slowly. Respect has been achieved.

MISS HATTIE
You can stay.

HARMONY
(head in her hands)
Mommy, I'm a doctor.

LILLIAN
(kissing the top of her head)
And doctors eat. I raised a doctor. Eat your greens, Doctor.

21 INT. PELL PAVILION - STAIRWELL B - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 2:11 PM

Concrete stairs, a fire door, the hum of old pipes. Marc runs down two steps at a time and almost collides with Esther, running up with a chart.

ESTHER
Where are you going?

MARC
Ravenswood. I need a birth certificate and a pay stub.

ESTHER
You're on call. You can't leave the building.

MARC
That's why I'm going to ask Mr. Freeman to go. He lives there. (beat) Where are you going?

ESTHER
To have a Teflon-coated electrode put into a jazz pianist's brain.

MARC
Our days are so different.

They stand there a beat, in each other's way.

MARC
Can I ask you something not about work?

ESTHER
No.

MARC
Where do you live?

ESTHER
(beat)
On a boat.

MARC
(genuinely delighted)
Like a pirate?

ESTHER
Like a sailboat. At the World's Fair Marina. It was cheaper than an apartment, and it floats, and nobody knows where I am.

MARC
That's the most romantic thing I've ever heard.

ESTHER
It's the least romantic thing in the world. The toilet is a bucket situation.

MARC
Still romantic.

ESTHER
(fighting a smile)
Marc. This isn't happening.

MARC
I know. I'm just asking about real estate.

She goes up the stairs. He goes down. Halfway, they both look back at the same moment. Caught. They both pretend they weren't.

22 INT. PELL PAVILION - PEDS SURGICAL STEP-DOWN - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 3:32 PM

Jalen, post-op and drowsy, an NG tube in his nose. Bernice sits beside him, exhausted. Marc enters with OLLIE FREEMAN (56), the night custodian, in street clothes, holding a manila envelope.

OLLIE
Mrs. Price. Ollie Freeman, building nine. Your neighbor Mrs. Tolliver let me in, said you'd want me to grab these. Birth certificate. Last two pay stubs. Con Ed bill.

BERNICE
(stunned)
You went to my apartment?

OLLIE
Doc asked. I live four floors under you. Been meaning to say hi for nine years.

Bernice takes the envelope. She looks at Marc.

BERNICE
What's this for?

MARC
It's insurance for Jalen. Child Health Plus. Temporary today, then real. So he gets to stay here, with Dr. Crump, until he's better.

BERNICE
(quietly)
I didn't know there was something like that.

MARC
Most people don't. That's the problem. (beat) Mr. Freeman, can you take that to Celia Montague in social work, second floor?

Ollie salutes and goes. Marc checks his watch: 3:36 PM. Transport's at six. His pager buzzes.

ON THE PAGER SCREEN: "CHIEF'S OFFICE. 4 PM. RE: PRICE TRANSFER. -- B. WATKINS"

Marc closes his eyes.

MARC
(to himself)
Somebody told.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

23 INT. OLD MAIN - CHIEF OF SURGERY'S OFFICE - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 4:01 PM

Afternoon light. Natasha behind her desk, fully the Chief. Gaskins in one chair. Marc standing. BERNIE WATKINS (55) closes the door on her way out and gives Marc a tiny, sympathetic look nobody else sees.

GASKINS
The transfer paperwork for Jalen Price was signed at 12:15 PM. It never reached the Pit. It was found an hour ago in the outgoing tray of the social work office.

NATASHA
(to Marc)
Did you hold up a transfer, Dr. Bullock?

MARC
No, ma'am.

NATASHA
Did you ask someone else to?

MARC
(beat)
I asked our social worker to see if the patient qualified for Child Health Plus. Which he does. The paperwork's being faxed to the state now.

GASKINS
That's not the point. The point is that an intern on his first week decided hospital policy didn't apply to his patient.

NATASHA
That is the point, Mr. Gaskins. (to Marc) Rule three on Dr. Bullock's service is that you don't lie. I'm adding a rule. In my hospital, interns don't decide policy. Not even when they're right. Especially when they're right. Do you understand why?

MARC
Because next time I might be wrong.

NATASHA
Because next time you might be wrong, and someone will die of your good intentions. (beat) Mr. Gaskins, if the coverage is approved by six, the transfer is moot and the patient stays. If it isn't, he goes.

GASKINS
(standing)
Thank you, Chief.

NATASHA
Dr. Bullock. Stay.

Gaskins leaves. The door closes. Natasha and Marc look at each other. She doesn't come around the desk. She doesn't hug him.

NATASHA
(quiet)
In this building I'm the Chief. I told you. No favors.

MARC
I didn't ask for one.

NATASHA
You didn't have to. You put me in a room where I either back a policy I hate or back my son in front of a man who'll remember it. (beat) Don't make me choose again.

MARC
(quiet)
The policy is wrong, Mom.

NATASHA
(sharp)
Chief.

MARC
The policy is wrong, Chief.

NATASHA
(beat, softer)
I know. Go get your coverage approved before six.

24 INT. PELL PAVILION - CORRIDOR - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 4:16 PM

Marc comes out of Old Main's elevators. Elxa is waiting, arms crossed, looking like a storm cloud in scrubs.

ELXA
You went to the Chief.

MARC
I got SENT to the Chief.

ELXA
On my service. Over a transfer on my service, about a patient on my service.

MARC
He's nine, Elxa.

ELXA
Dr. Bullock.

MARC
He's nine, Dr. Bullock.

Elxa looks at him for a long time.

ELXA
(low)
You think I don't know he's nine? You think I didn't stand in that OR and look at that baby's bowel and want to put my fist through a wall? (beat) I would have helped you. That's what I'm mad about. You didn't ask me.

That lands. Marc deflates.

MARC
I'm sorry.

ELXA
Rule two, the unwritten part. You page me before you page God. And apparently before you page Mommy.

She walks away. Then stops.

ELXA
(not turning)
Child Health Plus was smart. (beat) Don't tell anyone I said that.

25 INT. PELL PAVILION - OR 3 - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 4:38 PM

Augustus Freeland lies on the table, awake, his head fixed in a stereotactic frame. The drapes form a tent over his face so he can see and talk. Behind the drape, Graves works at the top of his skull with a NEUROPHYSIOLOGIST at a monitor of crackling brain signals.

Esther sits at Freeland's head, inside the drape tent, face to face with him.

FREELAND
My head is in a cage.

ESTHER
A very expensive cage. It's for your own good.

FREELAND
Like marriage.

ESTHER
(laughing)
Don't make me laugh. I'm supposed to keep you still.

GRAVES
(from behind the drape)
Electrode is at target. Ventral intermediate nucleus. Mr. Freeland, hold your right hand up in front of you. Like you're holding a glass.

Freeland raises his right hand. It shakes violently.

GRAVES
Turning on the stimulation. Two volts.

A moment. Nothing. Then the shaking slows... and slows... and stops. Freeland's hand hangs in the air, perfectly still. He stares at it.

FREELAND
(whispering)
Oh.

ESTHER
(tears springing)
Mr. Freeland.

FREELAND
Oh. Oh, Lord.

GRAVES
Tremor suppression complete. Any tingling? Speech changes?

FREELAND
(still staring at his hand)
Doctor, I haven't seen my hand hold still since Nixon.

He turns his hand. Spreads his fingers. Then, slowly, on the sterile drape, he begins to play: the fingers walking, then running, a silent piece only he can hear. His face is transfigured.

ESTHER
What are you playing?

FREELAND
(eyes closed, fingers flying)
"Lift Every Voice and Sing." For Keisha. For her mama. For your daddy, baby. For his hands.

Esther cries openly inside the drape tent. Graves, on the other side, pauses for a second and looks at the monitor. Then he quietly goes back to work.

26 INT. PELL PAVILION - ROOM 412 - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 5:11 PM

Lamar Pittman, dressed, MTA vest over his arm, discharge papers in hand. Harmony hands him his prescriptions.

HARMONY
Antibiotics, twice a day. No lifting more than ten pounds for two weeks. No track work for four. If you get a fever, come back.

PITTMAN
Yes, Doc.

HARMONY
(beat, then all at once)
Mr. Pittman, I need to tell you something. I didn't take your appendix out. I started. I froze. Dr. Bullock, the other Dr. Bullock, finished it. I'm sorry. You deserved someone who didn't freeze.

Pittman looks at her for a long moment.

PITTMAN
Big Howard ever tell you about the time he froze?

HARMONY
My daddy doesn't freeze.

PITTMAN
Winter of '96. The big blizzard. He's driving the Q4 on Merrick Boulevard with a bus full of people, and the bus slides, and he froze. Just sat there with his hands on the wheel. Thirty seconds. Then he got out in the snow and pushed. By himself. Got us all to the depot.

HARMONY
(tears)
He never told me that.

PITTMAN
'Cause the freezing isn't the story, Doc. The pushing's the story. (beat) You come find me on the 7 line when you're a big-time surgeon. I'll tell everybody you started it.

27 INT. OLD MAIN - SOCIAL WORK OFFICE - DAY
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 5:49 PM

The fax machine whirs. Celia stands over it. Marc paces behind her, watching the clock: 5:49. Raven is there too, eating the last of Lillian's pound cake out of foil.

RAVEN
Why is the fax so slow? Is it a 1997 fax?

CELIA
It's a 1989 fax. It has outlived three CEOs.

The fax beeps. A page begins to emerge, line by line. Celia pulls it out and reads.

CELIA
NEW YORK STATE, CHILD HEALTH PLUS. Presumptive eligibility determination. Jalen M. Price, DOB ten-two-ninety-five. Status... approved. Effective July 7, 2005.

Marc grabs Raven and lifts her right off her feet. She shrieks and holds the pound cake up out of harm's way.

CELIA
(picking up the phone)
Lowell? Celia. Your six o'clock is insured. (beat) Uh-huh. (beat) I love you too, Lowell. Cancel the ambulance.

She hangs up. Checks her watch: 5:52.

CELIA
Eight minutes. That's a record. My last record was eleven.

28 INT. PELL PAVILION - DR. ROBERT BULLOCK'S OFFICE - NIGHT
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 6:20 PM

A cardiothoracic chief's office: framed anatomical drawings of the heart, a turntable, and a shelf of vinyl, Coltrane, Monk and Mingus. Robert sits at his desk, signing op notes. Natasha comes in without knocking and shuts the door. For the first time, they're just husband and wife.

NATASHA
Your son called me "Mom" in front of Lowell Gaskins.

ROBERT
(not looking up)
Our son.

NATASHA
Your son, when he does things like this. Our son, when he gets into Hopkins.

Robert puts down his pen. Studies her.

ROBERT
What did he do?

NATASHA
Got a nine-year-old insured with a social worker and a 1989 fax machine, and "lost" a transfer form on the way.

ROBERT
(beat, the faintest smile)
Good.

NATASHA
Robert.

ROBERT
Tasha. My father drove a Metrobus for thirty-four years. Do you know how many times he let a kid ride without a fare?

NATASHA
Every day.

ROBERT
Every day. And he got written up for it every month. (beat) Our son comes by it honestly.

She sits on the arm of his chair. He leans into her.

NATASHA
Sylvia says we have two years. Maybe three. And then she said it out loud. My father. One phone call.

ROBERT
(instantly)
No.

NATASHA
I said no.

ROBERT
Good. The day we take his money is the day we stop being the people who built this.

A pause.

NATASHA
(quietly)
And if no means it closes?

Robert doesn't answer. He takes her hand. They sit with it.

NATASHA
Come home tonight. Real dinner. Not takeout off a budget report.

ROBERT
I'll be home by nine.

NATASHA
You said that last Thursday.

ROBERT
Last Thursday a man's aorta tore. (beat) I'll be home by nine-thirty.

29 INT. PELL PAVILION - THE PIT - CENTRAL STATION - NIGHT
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 6:34 PM

Evening shift change. Gloria is finishing her charts before going home, her purse on the counter. Marc comes by to drop off a chart, still glowing.

GLORIA
Heard you beat the fax machine.

MARC
Celia beat the fax machine. I just yelled at it.

GLORIA
Mm-hm. (without looking up) Heard you went up to the ninth floor today too.

MARC
The Chief wanted to talk to me.

GLORIA
Mm-hm. Baby, I've been in this Pit for thirty years. I've watched six Chiefs. You know what that woman has never once done in twelve years of walking through here at night?

MARC
(careful)
What?

GLORIA
Stop to talk to an intern. (beat) She stopped for you last Friday. She looked at you for two seconds longer than a Chief needs to look at anybody. And I know that look.

MARC
What look?

Gloria finally looks up at him.

GLORIA
That's a mama's look.

Marc's face does absolutely nothing. A perfect blank. It's the most suspicious thing he could possibly do.

MARC
I don't know what you mean.

GLORIA
(picking up her purse)
Mm-hm. Whatever it is, I don't need to know it. It's safe with me. (beat) But you might want to tell your face. Your face is terrible at secrets.

She leaves. Marc stands frozen at the station. Then he glances up through the Pit's high windows at Old Main across the courtyard. On the ninth floor, in a lit corner window, a silhouette stands watching.

Natasha. She steps back out of the window.

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

30 INT. PELL PAVILION - CT STEP-DOWN UNIT - ROOM 3 - NIGHT
THURSDAY, JULY 7, 2005 - 11:41 PM

Dim night lights. Darlene has gone home. Earl Wynn sleeps propped up, monitors glowing green. Amond sits in the corner chair with a cardiology textbook, checking the monitor every thirty seconds like a heartbeat of his own.

The monitor chimes softly. Amond looks up. Heart rate 118. Blood pressure 96/60. He frowns, gets up and checks the trend. An hour ago it was 132/80.

AMOND
Mr. Wynn. Mr. Wynn, wake up for me.

EARL
(groggy)
Kid. What time is it?

AMOND
How do you feel?

EARL
Like... like a cinder block's sitting on me. Can't get a good breath.

Amond moves fast. He looks at Earl's neck: the jugular veins are bulging. He presses his stethoscope to Earl's chest and listens. His face changes.

AMOND
(to himself)
Muffled.

The monitor: 88/58. The pulse pressure is narrowing. Amond hits the call button and grabs the phone.

AMOND
(into the phone)
Page Dr. Robert Bullock, STAT, CT step-down room 3. Possible tamponade. And get me an echo machine and a pericardiocentesis kit. Now!

A NIGHT NURSE runs in, then another. Earl's eyes are wide.

EARL
What's happening, kid?

AMOND
(steady, holding his hand for one second)
There's blood around your heart, squeezing it. We're going to let it out. You're going to be fine.

The phone rings. Amond grabs it.

ROBERT (V.O.)
(on the phone, wind noise, moving fast)
Talk.

AMOND
Post-op day six, pressure down from one-thirty-two to eighty-eight over fifty-eight in an hour, tachy to one-twenty-six, distended neck veins, muffled heart sounds.

ROBERT (V.O.)
Beck's triad. Echo?

A nurse wheels in a portable echo. Amond puts the probe below Earl's sternum. A dark ring around a heart that's barely moving.

AMOND
Large pericardial effusion. The right ventricle is collapsing.

ROBERT (V.O.)
I'm on the Queensboro Bridge. Twelve minutes. He doesn't have twelve minutes. (beat) Baker. Do you have the kit?

AMOND
(looking at the kit the nurse just opened)
Yes.

ROBERT (V.O.)
Then listen to me and do exactly what I say.

Amond puts the phone on speaker and sets it on the bed rail. He gloves. His hands are perfectly steady. His

breathing isn't.

ROBERT (V.O.)
Subxiphoid approach. Find the notch below his sternum. Go in just to the left of it, at a forty-five-degree angle, aiming at his left shoulder. Use the echo. Watch the needle the whole time.

AMOND
(doing it)
Entering...

ROBERT (V.O.)
Slowly. Aspirate as you go. You'll feel a pop. Tell me when.

Amond advances the long needle, aspirating, his eyes locked on the echo screen. Earl grips the bed rails.

AMOND
...Pop.

Dark blood fills the syringe. Amond draws back. Another syringe. Another. On the monitor, the blood pressure climbs: 92... 104... 118.

NIGHT NURSE
Pressure's coming up!

EARL
(gasping)
Oh, there it is. There's my breath. Kid, there's my breath.

The door BANGS open. Robert, in a dress shirt and tie, his car keys still in his hand, takes in the room in one second. Amond, needle in. The pressure is climbing. Earl is breathing.

ROBERT
(calm, already gloving)
How much have you drawn?

AMOND
(not looking away from the screen)
Two hundred and ten cc's.

ROBERT
Leave the needle. I'll place a drain. We'll take him back to the OR to find where it's bleeding.

He moves in beside Amond. For a moment they work together, hands side by side. Robert glances at the monitor. 122/76. Then at Amond.

31 INT. PELL PAVILION - CT STEP-DOWN CORRIDOR - NIGHT
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 12:22 AM

Earl is wheeled toward the OR, conscious, giving a thumbs-up as he goes by. Robert, now in scrubs, stops in front of Amond in the hallway. Amond's hands are shaking now that it's over.

ROBERT
You didn't wait for me.

AMOND
He didn't have twelve minutes.

ROBERT
(beat)
Correct.

Amond lets out a breath.

ROBERT
Most interns, faced with that, freeze or wait. Waiting is the most common way people die in hospitals, Dr. Baker. Not from the disease. From somebody waiting for somebody else. (beat) Come scrub. You'll watch me find the bleeder.

AMOND
Yes, sir.

ROBERT
And Baker. (beat) Your hands shake after. Not during. That's the right order. Keep it that way.

32 INT. PELL PAVILION - THE PIT - VENDING MACHINE ALCOVE - NIGHT
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 1:42 AM

A humming soda machine and a snack machine with one row of sad pretzels. Esther feeds dollar bills into the snack machine. It keeps spitting them back. Marc walks up behind her, takes the bill, flattens it on his scrub pants and feeds it in. The machine accepts it.

ESTHER
How did you do that?

MARC
You have to love the dollar. The machine can tell.

She hits a button. Pretzels drop. They both lean against the wall.

MARC
I heard about Mr. Freeland. The night nurses are talking about it. They said he played the whole floor to sleep.

ESTHER
I heard about Jalen. The day nurses are talking about it. They said you lifted Raven off the ground.

MARC
She was holding pound cake. I was very careful.

She laughs. Eats a pretzel. Then, quieter:

ESTHER
Why do you care so much? About everyone. The kid, his grandmother, Harmony, Amond. You've known all of us for a week. You act like you've known us forever.

Marc thinks about it seriously.

MARC
I grew up in a big family. Really big. Holidays were thirty people, forty. Someone was always sick, or broke, or getting divorced, or graduating. My grandmother has this rule. If somebody's at your table, they're yours. You don't get to pick and choose. (beat) Everybody here's at my table now.

ESTHER
(softly)
That's a nice rule.

MARC
She's a nice lady. Terrifying, but nice.

Esther looks at him for a long moment. Her hand drifts toward her collarbone, where the chain is. She stops herself.

ESTHER
Marc, there are things about me you don't...

Her pager goes off. She looks at it.

ESTHER
Freeland's asking for me. He wants to play one more.

MARC
Go. Go get your concert.

She goes. Halfway down the hall, she turns back.

ESTHER
Thanks for loving my dollar.

MARC
Anytime.

33 EXT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - THE ROOF - NIGHT
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 2:31 AM

The skyline glitters. Somewhere a siren. Amond sits on the air-conditioning unit, still in his OR cap, shaking slightly. Marc comes up with two ginger ales and hands him one.

AMOND
You weren't in the gallery.

MARC
I was in the hallway outside Room 3 with a crash cart. I heard the page and ran. The nurse wouldn't let me in. Said there were enough people.

AMOND
(beat)
You were in the hallway.

MARC
The pact says "the other one's in the gallery." There wasn't a gallery. I improvised.

Amond almost smiles. He drinks.

AMOND
I put a needle in a man's heart.

MARC
Around a man's heart. In the sac.

AMOND
Let me have this.

MARC
You put a needle in a man's heart.

They sit. Across the river, the Empire State Building glows over Midtown. Somewhere across an ocean, a city is counting its dead.

AMOND
I'm going to win the Cut.

MARC
You're definitely going to win the Cut.

AMOND
You're not even going to fight me?

MARC
I fought a fax machine today. I'm tired.

34 INT. PELL PAVILION - 4TH FLOOR - ON-CALL ROOM 4C - NIGHT
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 3:04 AM

Darkness. Whispers and laughter. The door with the famously broken lock swings open and light from the hallway floods in. Raven stands there, bleary, with a pillow.

On the bottom bunk, Arianna and Kendra spring apart. Arianna's scrub top is half off. Kendra smooths her hair.

Frozen tableau. Nobody moves.

RAVEN
(slowly)
The lock's broken.

ARIANNA
(deadly)
Since 1994. I've heard.

Kendra grabs her shoes and slides past Raven with a little wave.

KENDRA
Night, Dr. Ellison.

She's gone. Arianna sits on the bunk, pulling her top down, staring at the floor. Raven stays in the doorway.

ARIANNA
(low, furious, scared)
If you tell anybody...

RAVEN
I'm not going to tell anybody.

ARIANNA
You're going to tell Divine. You two live together.

RAVEN
I'm not going to tell anybody, Arianna. (beat) Earlier I asked if you were the kind who's never scared, or the kind who's scared all the time. I think I know now.

Arianna looks up, ready to fight. But Raven isn't mocking her. She's just standing there.

RAVEN
It's 2005 in New York City. People are going to have opinions. Not me, though.

Raven sets her pillow on the top bunk and climbs up without another word.

RAVEN
(from the top bunk, in the dark)
Good night, Gary, Indiana.

A long pause.

ARIANNA
(very quietly)
...Good night, Savannah.

35 INT. OLD MAIN - 9TH FLOOR - PRIVATE RESTROOM - NIGHT
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 3:47 AM

A small private restroom near the Chief's office. Elxa kneels at the toilet, throwing up. She flushes, sits back against the wall, sweating, eyes closed.

A knock. The door opens. Natasha, in reading glasses with a file under her arm, working late as always. She sees her daughter on the floor.

NATASHA
Elxa.

ELXA
(eyes still closed)
It's the fish.

NATASHA
There's no fish on the ninth floor.

ELXA
It followed me.

Natasha sets down the file. Kneels beside her, puts the back of her hand to Elxa's forehead.

NATASHA
How long has this been happening?

ELXA
A few days. A week. It's stress. It's the new interns. It's your son.

NATASHA
Are your breasts tender?

ELXA
(eyes snapping open)
MOM.

NATASHA
Are you tired in a way sleep doesn't fix? When was your last period?

Elxa opens her mouth to answer. Closes it. Counts. Her face changes.

ELXA
(slowly)
...I've been busy.

NATASHA
(gently)
Elxa. I'm an obstetrician. I've been an obstetrician for twenty-one years. I delivered half of Queens. (beat) Take a test.

Elxa stares at her mother. All of her toughness evaporates, and for one second she's just a scared twenty-seven-year-old on a bathroom floor.

ELXA
(whispering)
I can't be. Not now. Not during residency.

NATASHA
(taking her hand)
I had you during college, baby. You'd be amazed what you can do during.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

36 INT. PELL PAVILION - PEDS SURGICAL STEP-DOWN - NIGHT
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 4:12 AM

Bernice sleeps upright in the visitor's chair, finally, in her uniform. Jalen is awake, watching cartoons on mute. Marc slips in quietly and sits on the edge of the bed.

JALEN
(whispering)
Am I in trouble?

MARC
For what?

JALEN
For the magnets. For costing Grandma money.

MARC
(gently)
You're not costing her anything. You have insurance now. It's called Child Health Plus. You're a man with coverage.

JALEN
Is that good?

MARC
It's very good. It means you get to stay here with me and Dr. Crump until your belly's better.

Jalen thinks about that.

JALEN
The science fair's in September. My car's not done.

MARC
Then we'll finish it. No magnets in mouths.

JALEN
We?

MARC
I'll come to your science fair. I'm good at cars. I'm terrible at cars, actually. But I'm very supportive.

Jalen grins: the first grin all day.

JALEN
Dr. Bullock? Why do you care?

Marc looks at Bernice, asleep. At this small kid in a big bed.

MARC
Because somebody should, and today I was the somebody.

37 INT. PELL PAVILION - ROOM 618 - NIGHT
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 4:40 AM

Augustus Freeland sits up in bed, bandage on his head, awake and radiant. On the tray table in front of him, a small electronic keyboard that a nurse found in the chaplain's office. Esther sits in the visitor's chair.

FREELAND
You should be asleep.

ESTHER
So should you.

FREELAND
I've been asleep for thirty years, baby.

He puts his hands on the keys. They don't shake. He plays: soft, careful at first, then sure, the first bars of "Lift Every Voice and Sing," slow and churchy, the old notes filling the dark room.

Esther closes her eyes and listens. A tear runs down her face. She doesn't wipe it.

Two NIGHT NURSES appear in the doorway to listen. Then a third. An old man in the bed across the hall sits up.

FREELAND
(playing, not looking up)
Your daddy would be proud of you.

ESTHER
You never met him.

FREELAND
I know hands. You have his.

38 INT. OLD MAIN - RESIDENTS' LOUNGE - THE BOARD - DAY
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 5:22 AM

Dawn light. The interns crowd the Board, all of them exhausted and post-call. Amond stands closest, practically vibrating. Elxa comes in, pale but composed, and uncaps a marker.

ELXA
The Cut. One appendectomy, skin to skin, start to finish. Seven-thirty this morning, OR 4.

AMOND
(under his breath)
Come on.

ELXA
This week, Baker diagnosed a dissection, held an aorta and did an emergent pericardiocentesis at midnight on a post-op patient in tamponade, and it saved his life.

AMOND
(eyes closed)
Yes.

ELXA
Bullock got a nine-year-old insurance, diagnosed an aneurysm and broke a hospital policy in a way that I'm still deciding how I feel about. Smilley sat through a three-hour awake brain surgery and is apparently the reason a jazz pianist is playing for the night shift.

She writes a name on the Board, under THE CUT.

DIVINE.

Silence.

AMOND
(stunned)
What?

HARMONY
(more stunned)
What?

ELXA
I said "the best intern this week." I didn't say the best week. (to Harmony) You froze on day one. You've spent every day since looking at your own name on a bathroom door, and you didn't scrub it off. You told your patient the truth when nobody asked you to. That's not the best week. That's the best recovery. That's what I'm rewarding.

AMOND
That's... that's not what the rules said.

ELXA
Rule zero, Baker. I make the rules.

Harmony stares at her name on the Board. Raven squeezes her arm. Marc grins. Even Esther smiles. Arianna looks at the Board, expressionless.

ELXA
Divine. Seven-thirty. Don't freeze.

39 INT. PELL PAVILION - OR 4 - DAY
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 7:46 AM

The same OR as a week ago. A new patient: a 22-year-old man on the table, prepped and draped. Harmony at the table, gowned, gloved, scalpel in hand. Elxa across from her with her hands folded, not touching anything.

In the gallery: Marc, Raven, Esther and Amond (sulking, but there). And in the back, alone, arms crossed: Arianna.

ELXA
Whenever you're ready, Dr. Divine.

Harmony takes a breath. Her hand is steady.

HARMONY
Incision.

She cuts. Clean, confident. She works through the layers. Into the abdomen. She finds the cecum, follows the taenia, and there it is: an inflamed appendix, right where it's supposed to be this time.

HARMONY
(quietly)
There you are.

She clamps. Ligates. Divides. Each move steady and methodical. Elxa watches, hands still folded, saying nothing. Nothing needs saying.

HARMONY
Appendix is out. Stump is secure. No bleeding.

ELXA
(beat)
Close, Dr. Divine.

In the gallery, Raven grabs Marc's arm. Marc pumps his fist silently. Amond, despite himself, nods. In the back row, Arianna uncrosses her arms.

40 INT. PELL PAVILION - OR 4 SCRUB ROOM - DAY
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 8:41 AM

Harmony strips off her gown, shaking now with leftover adrenaline. She's grinning so hard it looks painful. Amond comes in from the gallery hallway and leans against the sink, arms folded.

AMOND
You tied the stump with a double ligature.

HARMONY
(bracing herself)
Is that... was that wrong?

AMOND
It was textbook. Literally. Page four hundred and twelve of Schwartz. (beat) I would have done a single and a purse-string.

HARMONY
Oh.

AMOND
Mine would have been faster.
Yours was better.

Harmony stares at him.

HARMONY
Was that a compliment?

AMOND
It was a fact. I only deal in facts. (beat) I still think I should've won.

HARMONY
You should have won.

AMOND
(thrown)
...You're not supposed to agree with me.

HARMONY
You put a needle in a man's heart, Amond. I took out an appendix. But I needed it more than you did. (beat) Thank you for being in the gallery.

Amond looks uncomfortable with the emotion. He pushes off the sink.

AMOND
Bullock made a pact. Whoever gets the case, the others are in the gallery. Apparently it applies to you too now. (at the door) Don't make it weird, Juneteenth.

HARMONY
(calling after him)
It's already weird!

41 INT. OLD MAIN - 3RD FLOOR WOMEN'S RESTROOM - DAY
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 9:03 AM

Harmony walks in, still in her OR cap, glowing, and goes to the last stall. She stops.

On the stall door, someone has crossed out "KILL" with a thick black line. Above it, in fresh Sharpie: "HEAL."

"DOUBLE-O DIVINE: LICENSED TO HEAL."

Harmony stares at it. She looks around the empty bathroom. Then she spots the Sharpie cap on the floor by the sink. She picks it up and smiles.

In the hallway outside, Arianna walks away fast, hands in her pockets, chewing her gum.

TAG

42 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - LIVING ROOM - DAY
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 12:37 PM

Post-call coma. Marc is sprawled across the entire couch. Raven is asleep in an armchair with a half-eaten grilled cheese. Harmony sits on the floor, still awake, too wired to sleep, with her pager in her hand.

She types a page.

ON THE PAGER SCREEN: OUTGOING TO MOMMY: "I DID MY FIRST APPENDECTOMY. ALL BY MYSELF. -- DR. DIVINE"

She hits send. Twenty seconds later it buzzes back.

ON THE PAGER SCREEN: "PRAISE GOD!!! DID U EAT. -- MOMMY"

Harmony laughs out loud. Marc, eyes closed, holds up a hand. She high-fives it without looking.

43 INT. ELXA AND RUSSELL'S HOUSE - ST. ALBANS, QUEENS - UPSTAIRS BATHROOM - DAY
FRIDAY, JULY 8, 2005 - 1:14 PM

A small, tidy bathroom in a two-family house. Elxa sits on the closed toilet lid, still in her clothes from the hospital, holding a drugstore pregnancy test. She's staring at it.

Two pink lines.

A gentle knock on the door. RUSSELL JEFFRIES (30), soft-spoken, a chemistry teacher's cardigan over a T-shirt, calls from the hallway.

RUSSELL (O.S.)
Babe? You've been in there twenty minutes. You okay?

Elxa looks at the two lines. Then at the door. Her hand goes, unconsciously, to her stomach.

MARC (V.O.)
Everybody gets a first cut. The first time you do the thing you were born to do, and find out whether your hands agree with your heart.

MARC (V.O.)
And nobody tells you that the second one is the one that counts. The one after you've frozen. After you've been wrong. After someone's written it on a wall.

Elxa sets the test on the edge of the sink, very carefully, like it might break.

ELXA
(calling out, steady)
I'm fine, Russell. (beat) Come here. Sit down. I have to tell you something.

MARC (V.O.)
The second cut is where you find out who you are.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE

Media Companion: Episode 1x02

Off-screen media around the episode, in chronological order. Not counted in page length (MA-009 §5).

NY1: BREAKING NEWS crawl

Thursday, July 7, 2005, 5:15 AM

"LONDON: EXPLOSIONS ON UNDERGROUND AND A BUS DURING MORNING RUSH ... NYPD DEPLOYS ADDITIONAL OFFICERS TO SUBWAYS, BRIDGES AND TUNNELS ... MTA URGES RIDERS: IF YOU SEE SOMETHING, SAY SOMETHING ..."

AIM: AortaOrBust79 (Amond Baker) and HarvardHeart_Mom (Harriet Baker-Fenwick)

Thursday, July 7, 2005, 6:20 AM

HarvardHeart_Mom: are you safe. london. the news.

AortaOrBust79: I'm in Queens, Mom.

HarvardHeart_Mom: queens has subways

AortaOrBust79: I walk.

HarvardHeart_Mom: are you eating

AortaOrBust79: I held an aorta last week.

HarvardHeart_Mom: that is not food amond

AortaOrBust79's away message: "On call. Saving lives. Not eating."

QUEENS CHRONICLE: Queens Grace Welcomes 18 New Surgeons-in-Training

Thursday, July 7, 2005 (on newsstands)

LONG ISLAND CITY. Eighteen new surgical interns climbed to the roof of Queens Grace Hospital at 5:30 a.m. last Friday, July 1... "Some of you will not finish," Chief of Surgery Dr. Natasha Donohue told the class. "The ones who do will never be the same."

Also in this issue: "Olympic Dream Ends: New York Loses 2012 Bid to London" (p. 6).

MySpace: bulletin from KeKe_SouthJamaica

Thursday, July 7, 2005, 7:02 PM

"UPDATE!!! DESTINY went home from Queens Grace today!!! she says the doctor who saved her is TALL and corny, and she made him a sign that says FRONT ROW RESERVED. Miss Teen Queens is NEXT SATURDAY now. she can't compete but she's coming to WATCH. we ride at dawn." Reposts: 88

QueensGraceConfidential (Blogger)

Friday, July 8, 2005, 1:52 AM

"WEEK ONE awards, Gracelings edition. MOST LIKELY TO GET FIRED: Tall Dimples, who reportedly got a kid insured AND got called to the 9th floor in the same afternoon. BEST DRAMA: a certain intern's MOTHER versus Miss Hattie, round one, over mac and cheese (Miss Hattie let her stay, which has NEVER happened). MOST PROMISING: the Harvard one, who stuck a needle in a man's heart at midnight. And to whoever keeps editing the bathroom door on 3: we see you." Comments (37).

SMS, Motorola RAZR (Elxa Bullock to Grace Bullock)

Friday, July 8, 2005, 1:31 PM

Elxa: "Don't tell Mom I told you first. Actually Mom already knows. Don't tell Marc. Call me."

Grace: "???????? TELL WHAT"

Grace: "ELXA"

Grace: "ELXA CALL ME"

Continuity Sheet: Episode 1x02

New Canon Established

- **The Cut:** Elxa's weekly incentive for the best intern on her service. Week one's winner was Harmony Divine, for 'the best recovery.' Elxa: 'Rule zero: I make the rules.'
- **Elxa is pregnant.** Natasha diagnosed it at 3:47 AM on July 8, and the test was positive at 1:14 PM. At the end of the episode she's telling Russell. Grace knows something's up; Marc doesn't know. (This is consistent with the birth on February 5, 2006, about 30 weeks later.)
- **Gloria knows Marc is hiding something** (MA-005). She suspects Natasha is his mother ('That's a mama's look') and has promised silence. It hasn't been confirmed to her.
- **Arianna and Kendra Wallace** are involved. Raven walked in on them (on-call room 4C, 3:04 AM, July 8) and promised silence. Arianna and Raven now call each other 'Gary, Indiana' and 'Savannah.'
- **'LICENSED TO HEAL':** Arianna secretly rewrote the graffiti on the 3rd-floor bathroom door. Harmony found the Sharpie cap.
- Esther told Augustus Freeland (and only him, so far) about her father's murder. Graves told her to chart her own observations.
- Marc now knows Esther lives on a sailboat at the World's Fair Marina. It's still 'not happening.'
- **Natasha's new rule:** 'In my hospital, interns don't decide policy. Not even when they're right.' Marc called her 'Mom' at work once, and she corrected him to 'Chief.'
- Sylvia Rountree says the deficit is on pace for $44M this year, with 'two years, maybe three' left. Natasha refused Foundation money again.
- Marc's peds origin: at 11 (1990), his uncle Lawrence took him to a Donohue children's hospital in Atlanta, where a girl beat him at chess four times.
- Lamar Pittman's story: Howard Divine froze for 30 seconds driving the Q4 in the January 1996 blizzard, then got out and pushed the bus himself.

Knowledge Tracker: Marc's True Identity (as of July 8, 2005)

Knows	Suspects	Doesn't know
Natasha, Robert, Elxa, Grace, Victor, Joan, the Donohue uncles, Grandma Jo, Bernie Watkins, Dr. Graves	Gloria Pettiford (believes Natasha is his mother)	Amond, Esther, Arianna, Harmony, Raven, Monty, Gaskins, Celia, Dr. Crump and everyone else

Patient Registry

Patient	DOB / age	Diagnosis	Procedure / surgeon	Outcome
Jalen Price	10/2/1995 (9)	Ingestion of two magnets, with bowel perforations and a fistula	Laparotomy, magnet removal, small-bowel resection (Crump; Elxa, Marc)	Stable. Child Health Plus approved 5:52 PM; no transfer

Patient	DOB / age	Diagnosis	Procedure / surgeon	Outcome
Augustus Freeland	2/22/1931 (74)	Essential tremor	Awake thalamic (VIM) deep brain stimulation (Graves; Esther at the head)	Tremor suppressed. Plays the July 16 wedding at Abyssinian
Earl Wynn	11/2/1946 (58)	Post-op pericardial tamponade (day 6)	Emergent subxiphoid pericardiocentesis (Amond, phone-guided by Robert); back to the OR (Robert)	Stable
Lamar Pittman	1/14/1971 (34)	Post-appendectomy	Discharged by Harmony	Home
Unnamed male	(22)	Acute appendicitis	Open appendectomy, skin to skin (Harmony; Elxa supervising)	Uncomplicated. Harmony's first full case
Destiny Lockhart	3/3/1988 (17)	Post-clipping	Discharged July 7 (off-screen; per Media Companion)	Home. Will watch the pageant July 16

New Characters (to add to MA-005 and MA-006)

- **Dr. Isaiah Crump**, b. March 11, 1944 (61). Chief of Pediatric Surgery, QGH. Wears bow ties; nearing retirement. Recurring.
- **Lowell Gaskins**, b. March 27, 1961 (44). Patient Financial Services. Has three kids. 'I don't write the rules.' Recurring.
- **Jalen Price** (b. October 2, 1995) and **Bernice Price** (b. December 4, 1946), from the Ravenswood Houses. Marc has promised to go to Jalen's September science fair.
- **Augustus Freeland**, b. February 22, 1931, a retired Blue Note pianist. **Darlene Wynn**, b. May 19, 1950, Earl's wife.

Real-World Accuracy Notes

- July 7, 2005: the London Underground blasts came at about 8:50 AM BST (3:50 AM EDT) and the Tavistock Square bus bomb at 9:47 AM BST. That day the NYPD surged officers into the transit system. New York had lost the 2012 Olympic bid to London on July 6.
- Child Health Plus (New York, since 1991), presumptive eligibility for children, and EMTALA's rules on transfer after stabilization are all real 2005 mechanisms.
- The medicine is accurate: multiple-magnet ingestion causing pressure necrosis and a fistula; VIM DBS for essential tremor, done awake with intraoperative testing; Beck's triad and echo-guided subxiphoid pericardiocentesis for post-op tamponade.